KARATINA UNIVERSITY

School of Arts, Humanities and Social Sciences

FUNDAMENTALS OF POLITICAL THEORY

Student Study Notes

Covers: nature and scope of political theory; key concepts (state, sovereignty, power, authority, legitimacy); theories of the state; classical and modern political thinkers; political ideologies; democracy, justice, rights and citizenship; and revision questions.

Compiled as a revision aid. Always read alongside your unit outline, prescribed textbooks and lecturer's notes.

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UNIT 1: INTRODUCTION TO POLITICAL THEORY

1.1 What is Political Theory?

Political theory is the branch of political science concerned with the systematic study of ideas about government, power, the state, justice and the rights and duties of citizens. It asks fundamental questions such as: What is the state? Why should people obey political authority? What makes a political system just? How should power be distributed and controlled?

Definition — Political Theory: *A body of thought that examines, explains and evaluates political concepts, institutions and practices, combining empirical description with normative (value) judgement about how political life ought to be organised.*

1.2 Nature of Political Theory

- It is both **descriptive** (explaining how political systems actually work) and **normative/prescriptive** (evaluating how they ought to work).
- It is interdisciplinary, drawing from philosophy, history, sociology, economics and law.
- It deals with abstract concepts such as power, justice, liberty, equality and rights.
- It evolves with time — theories reflect the historical and social context in which they were developed.

1.3 Scope of Political Theory

- The study of the **state** — its origin, nature, purpose and forms.
- The study of **government** — its institutions, organs and functions.
- The study of key **political concepts** — sovereignty, power, authority, legitimacy, liberty, equality, justice, rights.
- The study of **political ideologies** that shape how societies organise power.
- The study of the relationship between the **individual and the state**.

1.4 Importance of Political Theory to Students

- Provides the conceptual vocabulary used throughout political science and public administration.
- Equips students with tools to critically analyse government policy and political events.
- Helps in understanding the origin and justification of political institutions.
- Builds the foundation for further study in comparative politics, public policy, international relations and constitutional law.

UNIT 2: APPROACHES TO THE STUDY OF POLITICAL THEORY

Scholars study political phenomena using different approaches. Each approach offers a different lens for analysing power, institutions and political behaviour.

2.1 Normative (Philosophical) Approach

Focuses on values and asks how political life *ought* to be organised. It is concerned with concepts like justice, the good life, and the ideal state. Associated with thinkers such as Plato and Rawls.

2.2 Historical Approach

Studies political ideas in the context of the historical period in which they arose, showing how political thought develops and responds to changing circumstances.

2.3 Institutional (Traditional) Approach

Focuses on the formal structures of government — constitutions, the legislature, the executive and the judiciary — and how they are organised and function.

2.4 Behavioural Approach

A modern, empirical approach that studies the actual behaviour of political actors (voters, leaders, parties) using scientific methods, data and observation rather than abstract values alone.

2.5 Marxist Approach

Analyses politics as a reflection of economic class relations, viewing the state as an instrument used by the dominant economic class to maintain control over the means of production.

2.6 Systems Approach

Views the political system as a set of interrelated institutions and processes that convert societal 'inputs' (demands and support) into 'outputs' (policies and decisions), an idea developed by David Easton.

UNIT 3: KEY CONCEPTS IN POLITICAL THEORY

3.1 The State

Definition — State: *A political community occupying a defined territory, organised under a government, and possessing sovereignty — the supreme authority to make and enforce laws within its territory.*

- **Elements of a state:** population, defined territory, government, and sovereignty.
- The state is distinguished from the **government** (the machinery that runs the state) and from the **nation** (a group bound by common identity, which may or may not correspond to a state).

3.2 Sovereignty

Definition — Sovereignty: *The supreme, final and absolute authority within a political community, above which there is no higher legal authority.*

- **Internal sovereignty:** supreme authority over all persons and groups within the state's territory.
- **External sovereignty:** independence from control by other states in the conduct of foreign affairs.
- **Legal sovereignty:** the authority recognised by law as having the final say (e.g. Parliament).
- **Popular sovereignty:** the doctrine that ultimate authority rests with the people.

3.3 Power

Definition — Power: *The capacity or ability of an individual or group to influence the behaviour of others, with or without their consent, and even against their resistance.*

Max Weber distinguished power (the ability to compel obedience) from authority (power that is recognised as rightful).

3.4 Authority

Definition — Authority: *Legitimate power — the right to command obedience, recognised and accepted as rightful by those who are governed.*

Weber's Three Types of Authority

- **Traditional authority** — based on long-established customs and traditions (e.g. hereditary kingship).
- **Charismatic authority** — based on the exceptional personal qualities of a leader.
- **Legal-rational authority** — based on formal rules and laws, typical of modern bureaucratic states.

3.5 Legitimacy

Definition — Legitimacy: *The popular acceptance of a government's or ruler's right to exercise power and make binding decisions.*

A government may possess power without legitimacy (e.g. a military junta) or seek to build legitimacy through elections, tradition, performance or ideology.

3.6 Liberty, Equality and Justice (introduced here, expanded in Unit 8)

- **Liberty** — freedom from undue restraint, allowing individuals to act, think and express themselves.
- **Equality** — the idea that individuals should be treated as having equal worth and be given equal opportunities or rights.
- **Justice** — the principle of giving each person their due; fairness in the distribution of benefits and burdens in society.

UNIT 4: THEORIES OF THE ORIGIN OF THE STATE

4.1 The Divine Origin Theory

Holds that the state was created by God and that rulers derive their authority from divine will (the 'Divine Right of Kings'). It justified absolute monarchy in medieval Europe and made political obedience a religious duty.

4.2 The Force Theory

Argues that the state originated when a strong individual or group conquered and subdued a weaker population, then organised it under centralised control. Force created the state, and force maintained it.

4.3 The Social Contract Theory

Holds that the state arose out of a voluntary agreement ('contract') among individuals who left a 'state of nature' to form political society for mutual protection and order. Its three main proponents are compared below.

Thinker	State of Nature	The Contract	Resulting Government
Thomas Hobbes (Leviathan, 1651)	"Nasty, brutish and short" — a war of all against all	People surrender all rights to an absolute sovereign	Absolute monarchy/sovereign with unlimited power
John Locke (Two Treatises, 1689)	Relatively peaceful, governed by natural law, but insecure	People surrender only some rights to protect life, liberty and property	Limited government; people may overthrow it if it breaks the tr
Jean-Jacques Rousseau (Social Contract, 1762)	Free and equal, corrupted by the rise of private property	Individuals merge their wills into the general will	Popular sovereignty and direct democracy

4.4 The Evolutionary Theory

Argues that the state developed gradually over time through the natural evolution of the family into clans, tribes and eventually complex political communities, rather than through a single deliberate contract or act of force.

4.5 The Marxist Theory

Sees the state as arising from the division of society into economic classes. Once society produced a surplus and private property emerged, the state was created as an instrument of the dominant (property-owning) class to protect its economic interests and suppress the exploited class.

UNIT 5: CLASSICAL AND MODERN POLITICAL THINKERS

Plato (c. 428–348 BC)

Key work(s): *The Republic*

- Advocated rule by 'philosopher-kings' trained in wisdom and virtue.
- Classified society into three classes: rulers (guardians), soldiers (auxiliaries) and producers (workers), each performing the role suited to its nature.
- Justice exists when each class performs its proper function without interfering with others.

Aristotle (384–322 BC)

Key work(s): *Politics*

- Called man 'a political animal' (zoon politikon) who can only achieve the good life within a political community.
- Classified constitutions by who rules and in whose interest: monarchy/tyranny, aristocracy/oligarchy, and polity/democracy (mob rule).
- Favoured a 'polity' — a mixed constitution dominated by a large, stable middle class.

Niccolò Machiavelli (1469–1527)

Key work(s): *The Prince*

- Separated politics from morality, arguing rulers should be judged by results, not ethical means.
- Advised that it is safer for a ruler to be feared than loved, if he cannot be both.
- Regarded as a founder of modern, realist political thought.

Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679)

Key work(s): *Leviathan*

- Described the state of nature as a condition of constant war and insecurity.
- Argued for an all-powerful sovereign ('Leviathan') to guarantee peace and security.

John Locke (1632–1704)

Key work(s): *Two Treatises of Government*

- Argued that individuals possess natural rights to life, liberty and property.
- Government exists by the consent of the governed and can be overthrown if it violates this trust.
- Regarded as the father of political liberalism.

Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778)

Key work(s): *The Social Contract*

- Believed man is born free but is 'everywhere in chains' due to social institutions.
- Introduced the concept of the 'general will' as the basis of legitimate political authority.

Karl Marx (1818–1883)

Key work(s): *The Communist Manifesto*, *Das Kapital*

- Viewed history as a series of class struggles between the oppressor and the oppressed.
- Argued that the capitalist state serves the interests of the bourgeoisie (owners of capital) against the proletariat (workers).

- Predicted the eventual overthrow of capitalism and the emergence of a classless, stateless communist society.

John Stuart Mill (1806–1873)

Key work(s): *On Liberty*, *Utilitarianism*

- Defended individual liberty, limited only by the 'harm principle' — that power may only be exercised over an individual to prevent harm to others.
- Developed utilitarian ethics: the right action is that which produces 'the greatest happiness for the greatest number.'

UNIT 6: POLITICAL IDEOLOGIES

A political ideology is a coherent set of ideas and beliefs about how political, economic and social life should be organised, which shapes and justifies political action.

Liberalism

- Emphasises individual freedom, limited government, rule of law, and free markets.
- Believes government exists to protect individual rights, not to dictate how people should live.

Conservatism

- Values tradition, established institutions, gradual (not radical) change, and social order.
- Sceptical of rapid reform; believes society is best improved incrementally.

Socialism

- Advocates collective or state ownership/control of the means of production.
- Emphasises equality, social welfare and the reduction of class-based inequality.

Marxism-Communism

- A revolutionary form of socialism calling for abolition of private property and class society.
- Envisions a classless, stateless society achieved through proletarian revolution.

Fascism

- Extreme authoritarian nationalism, glorifying the state, a single leader, and national unity over individual rights.
- Hostile to liberal democracy, pluralism and communism.

Feminism

- Advocates political, social and economic equality between men and women.
- Analyses and challenges patriarchal structures within political and social institutions.

Nationalism

- Emphasises the interests, culture and self-determination of a nation or people.
- Often linked to the drive for independent statehood and national unity.

UNIT 7: THEORIES OF DEMOCRACY

Definition — Democracy: *A system of government in which political power ultimately rests with the people, exercised directly or through freely elected representatives.*

7.1 Classical/Direct Democracy

Citizens participate directly in decision-making, as practised in ancient Athens where eligible citizens voted directly on laws and policy.

7.2 Liberal/Representative Democracy

Citizens elect representatives to make decisions on their behalf, within a framework of constitutional limits, civil liberties, free elections and the rule of law.

7.3 Participatory Democracy

Emphasises broad citizen involvement in decision-making beyond just voting, such as through referenda, public forums and civic organisations.

7.4 Deliberative Democracy

Stresses that legitimate decisions should emerge from reasoned public discussion and debate among citizens, not merely aggregated votes.

7.5 Elitist Theory of Democracy

Associated with Joseph Schumpeter; argues that in practice democracy functions mainly as a competition among elites for the people's vote, rather than genuine rule by the masses.

7.6 Pillars/Conditions for Democracy

- Free, fair and regular elections
- Rule of law and an independent judiciary
- Protection of fundamental human rights and freedoms
- Freedom of the press and association
- Political pluralism (multiple parties and viewpoints)
- Accountability and transparency of government

UNIT 8: JUSTICE, RIGHTS AND CITIZENSHIP

8.1 Theories of Justice

Plato's Theory

Justice is a harmonious state in which each class in society (rulers, soldiers, producers) performs its proper function without encroaching on the roles of others.

Aristotle's Theory

Distinguished **distributive justice** (fair distribution of goods according to merit/contribution) from **corrective justice** (fair remedy for wrongs done between individuals).

John Rawls's Theory (A Theory of Justice, 1971)

- Proposes imagining principles of justice chosen behind a 'veil of ignorance', where no one knows their future place in society.
- **First principle:** each person has an equal right to the most extensive basic liberties compatible with similar liberties for others.
- **Second principle (the 'difference principle'):** social and economic inequalities are just only if they benefit the least advantaged members of society.

8.2 Rights

Definition — Rights: *Entitlements or freedoms that individuals possess, which others (including the state) are obliged to respect or provide.*

- **Natural/human rights** — inherent to all persons by virtue of being human (e.g. right to life).
- **Legal/civil rights** — rights granted and protected by the law of a particular state.
- **Political rights** — rights to participate in political life (e.g. right to vote).
- **Socio-economic rights** — rights to social goods such as education, health and housing (entrenched in the Kenyan Constitution 2010, Article 43).

8.3 Citizenship

Definition — Citizenship: *The status of being a legally recognised member of a state, carrying with it a set of rights (e.g. to vote, to protection) and duties (e.g. to obey the law, pay taxes).*

- **Liberal view:** citizenship as a bundle of legal rights protecting the individual.
- **Civic-republican view:** citizenship as active participation in public/political life for the common good.

UNIT 9: POLITICAL OBLIGATION

Definition — Political Obligation: *The moral duty of citizens to obey the laws and support the political institutions of the state under which they live.*

Main Grounds Advanced for Political Obligation

- **Consent theory** — obligation arises because citizens have consented (expressly or tacitly) to be governed (Locke).
- **Social contract** — obligation flows from the hypothetical original agreement to leave the state of nature (Hobbes, Rousseau).
- **Utility/benefit theory** — obligation is owed because citizens receive benefits (security, services) from the state.
- **Fair play theory** — those who benefit from a cooperative scheme have a duty to do their fair share in maintaining it.
- **Natural duty theory** — a general moral duty to support just institutions, regardless of consent.

Limits of Political Obligation

Most theories accept that the duty to obey is not absolute — it may be limited where government becomes tyrannical, violates fundamental rights, or breaks the trust placed in it, opening room for civil disobedience or, in Locke's view, a right to revolt.

UNIT 10: REVISION QUESTIONS

Short-Answer / Definition Questions

- Define political theory and explain its scope.
- Distinguish between power, authority and legitimacy.
- Distinguish between the state, the government and the nation.
- What is sovereignty? Distinguish internal from external sovereignty.
- Distinguish Hobbes's, Locke's and Rousseau's versions of the social contract.

Essay Questions

- "The state is an instrument of class domination." Discuss this Marxist claim with reference to at least two other theories of the origin of the state.
- Critically examine Plato's theory of justice. To what extent is it relevant to modern political society?
- Compare and contrast liberal representative democracy with participatory democracy.
- Discuss the main theories advanced to explain why citizens are obligated to obey the state.
- Examine the relevance of Rawls's theory of justice to addressing inequality in contemporary society.
- "Authority is legitimised power." Discuss, using Weber's typology of authority.

End of Notes — Fundamentals of Political Theory. Prepared as a revision guide for Karatina University students; supplement with your course outline, prescribed textbooks and lecture material.